

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/26: The clause, the one question, and the definition that decides it

SYLLABUS CLAUSE (verbatim): "Religion without God."

CENTRAL QUESTION: is belief in a PERSONAL CREATOR necessary for something to be a religion?

NOT the existence question. Nothing here turns on whether God exists.

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SUBSTANTIVE	FUNCTIONAL	MULTIDIMENSIONAL	FAMILY RESEMBLANCE
by its OBJECT	by what it	by a CLUSTER	no single feature is
God / gods /	DOES: ultimacy,	(Ninian Smart's	shared by every member
sacred beings	practice,	seven dimensions)	-> "religion" names a
	community,		family of practices,
	meaning,		not one essence
	liberation		
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TOO NARROW	TOO BROAD	THE WORKABLE MIDDLE
excludes Buddhism BY	admits nationalism,	creator-belief is NOT on the
STIPULATION	art, political cause	essential list
= QUESTION-BEGGING	= EMPTY CATEGORY	

SMART'S SEVEN DIMENSIONS: doctrinal | mythic | ethical | ritual | experiential | social | material

THE ONE RULE: every printed stem in this clause is decided by the definition you adopt in the first three lines. State it, defend it in one line, then apply it CONSISTENTLY.

THE FIREWALL: NON-THEISTIC is not identical with ATHEISTIC. Rejecting a creator does not entail denying every deity, sacred being, devotional act or transcendent value.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/26: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors

ORIGIN RAIL (conceptual, not calendar)

1 a definition of religion is proposed that centres on a personal creator

-> 2 established traditions are produced with doctrine, ritual, ethics, community and liberation, yet no creator

-> 3 the definition is defended by NARROWING it => the question-begging charge

-> 4 the definition is defended by WIDENING it => nationalism and ideology walk in

-> 5 a middle criterion is demanded: sacred order + disciplined soteriological practice

=> the clause exists because Stages 3 and 4 are BOTH unacceptable.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these; invent no others)

1843-44 Marx, Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right

1869 T. H. Huxley coins the word "agnostic"

1934 John Dewey, A Common Faith 1980 Don Cupitt, Taking Leave of God

1996 Robin Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism

1998 Ursula Goodenough, The Sacred Depths of Nature

2013 Ronald Dworkin, Religion without God <== the book that names this clause

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY YEAR: Nietzsche (The Gay Science 125; On the Genealogy of Morality);

Feuerbach (The Essence of Christianity); Freud (religion as illusion); Comte (Religion of

Humanity); Spinoza (Deus sive Natura); Ninian Smart (dimensions); Jaimini (Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2);

Kumarila (Slokavarttika); Madhava (Sarvadarsanasamgraha - REPORTED Carvaka only);

Brahmajala Sutta DN 1; Agganna Sutta DN 27; Julian Huxley; Crosby; Rue; Eshleman; Wettstein.

ANACHRONISM CONTROL: the Indian systems are NOT responses to the death of God; they never had the theistic horizon Nietzsche mourns. Keep POST-THEISM and NON-THEISM in separate paragraphs.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/26: The seven candidate criteria, graded

CANDIDATE FEATURE	NECESSARY?	WHY NOT SUFFICIENT ALONE
personal creator God	NO - Buddhism, Jainism, classical Mimamsa are counterexamples	defines THEISM, not religion as such
sacred / ultimate concern	strong but VERY BROAD	nations, art, political causes qualify
ritual + disciplined practice	widespread, not universal in one form	secular ceremonies also have ritual
ethical orientation	common	ethical philosophies are not religions
community and tradition	common	clubs and nations organise community too
DIAGNOSIS AND LIBERATION	STRONG DISCRIMINATOR	some traditions stress worship or belonging
myth, doctrine, experience	family features	each may be thin or absent in a strand
THE WORKING SUFFICIENT CLUSTER (write this, not a list of necessary conditions)		
a SOCIALLY EMBODIED and DISCIPLINED orientation to an ULTIMATE / SACRED ORDER, expressed through some combination of doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, and directed at a TRANSFORMATIVE or SOTERIOLOGICAL goal.		
TWO LOAD-BEARING CONDITIONS: sacred order AND transformative practice. Both, never either.		
ADMITS: Buddhism Jainism Mimamsa Samkhya-Yoga		
EXCLUDES: any strong commitment as such (nationalism, ideology) AND Carvaka.		

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/26: Which religious functions actually require a deity

FUNCTION	PERSONAL DEITY REQUIRED?	NON-THEISTIC FORM
petitionary prayer	YES, normally - a responsive addressee is built into petition	meditation, aspiration, recitation (NOT petition in the same sense)
worship / veneration	no	reverence for Dharma, liberated exemplars, scripture, sacred value
propositional revelation from God	YES, by definition	Mimamsa: AUTHORLESS scriptural authority, not creator-revelation
grace and providence	YES, in their personal-agency sense	self-effort, karmic law, disciplined path, communal support
ritual efficacy	no	apurva; Buddhist / Jain discipline
moral motivation	no	compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight, human flourishing
liberation / salvation	no, as a GENERIC function	nirvana, Jain release, kaivalya

THE SEPARABILITY RESULT: God is necessary for SOME SPECIFICALLY THEISTIC GOODS, not for every religious function. Mimamsa proves inside ONE system that AUTHORITY, EFFICACY and DESERT are each separable and can each be secured otherwise.

ANSWER MOVE: concede petition, grace and covenant. The concession buys credit for every denial that follows, and identifies where the theist's real case lies - devotional, not definitional.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/26: The four negative positions, and what each leaves standing

NON-THEISM	ATHEISM	AGNOSTICISM	INDIFFERENCE	
about the	about what	about what can	about what is	
PATH	EXISTS	be KNOWN	ASKED	
creator is	"God does not	WEAK: "not known"	the question does	
absent from	exist"	STRONG: "un-	not arise	
diagnosis		knowable"		
and path				
LEAVES	leaves the	leaves ethical,	leaves nothing in	
STANDING:	sacred order	experiential,	particular	
lesser gods,	ONLY if it is	ritual and		
devotion,	non-divine	communal		
sacred value,	(Carvaka does	religion		
soteriology	NOT)	available		

RELATED BUT DISTINCT: anti-theism (God-belief is harmful as well as false); practical atheism (a life organised without reference to God).

BURDENS DIFFER: the non-theist must show a path can be COMPLETE; the atheist must defend a UNIVERSAL NEGATIVE; the agnostic must show suspension coexists with practice.

THE RULE: religion survives NON-THEISM; it does not survive the removal of every sacred order.

THE FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS AS A DIAGNOSIS

- | | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 1 | THERE IS SUFFERING (duhkha) | <- the datum |
| 2 | IT HAS AN ORIGIN: craving + ignorance | <- the cause |
| 3 | THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE | <- the possibility |
| 4 | THERE IS A PATH TO ITS CESSATION | <- the prescription |

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V

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratityasamutpada): "this being, that becomes" - conditions arise, conditions cease. Karma supplies moral-causal continuity.

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WHERE WOULD A CREATOR GO?

WHAT ABOUT THE GODS?

[VACANT SLOT] - no step of the diagnosis, the cause, the cessation or the path requires one. devas and Brahma figures may occur in the cosmology, but they are IMPERMANENT beings INSIDE samsara: neither creators nor final saviours. Text anchors: Brahmajala Sutta DN 1; Agganna Sutta DN 27.

THE CLAIM IS REDUNDANCY, NOT REFUTATION. A creator adds no explanatory and no practical step.

PRESUPPOSITION, STATED HONESTLY: dependent causation is explanatorily sufficient FOR THE PROBLEM
BUDDHISM ADDRESSES - not for everything whatever. That is where a theist should press.

SCOPE CONTROL: the undeclared questions (avyakata) concern SPECIFIC speculative issues; they are NOT the whole Buddhist case. The poisoned-arrow parable = urgency, never proof of atheism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/26: Buddhism II - the cluster discharged, element by element

CLUSTER ELEMENT	WHAT BUDDHISM SUPPLIES	NEEDS A CREATOR?
doctrine	Four Noble Truths; dependent origination; impermanence and non-self	no
ritual / practice	meditation; recitation; monastic observance; later devotional (puja) forms	no
ethical formation	moral discipline (sila): right speech, action, livelihood	no
experience	staged meditative attainment; insight	no
community	the SANGHA - rule, ordination, transmission	no
soteriological goal	NIRVANA - liberation from suffering	no
sacred order	DHARMA - the order the path discloses	no

THE COMPULSORY QUALIFICATION: Dharma, Sangha and nirvana organise doctrine, practice and value WITHOUT functioning as ONE-FOR-ONE SUBSTITUTES for a personal creator.

=> saying "Dharma takes the place of God" is exactly the sentence the hidden-God objection needs.

2024 STEM SHAPE (state and evaluate, 20 marks): complete the STATEMENT before the EVALUATION.

Half the marks are in the exposition; evaluating a caricature forfeits the other half.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/26: Buddhism III - the devotional complication, handled correctly

LATER MAHAYANA devotion to Buddhas and bodhisattvas is real, widespread and religiously serious.

TWO TEMPTATIONS, BOTH WRONG

X "so Buddhism became theistic" - function mistaken for ontology

X "so it must be a later corruption" - an evidential claim you cannot support

THE CORRECT LINE

V Buddhas and bodhisattvas may perform religious FUNCTIONS - refuge, gratitude, aspiration, even grace-like assistance - WITHOUT thereby becoming an omnipotent creator.

V NON-THEISTIC DOES NOT MEAN DEVOTION-FREE. One sentence disarms the objection.

THREE OBJECTIONS AND THEIR REPLIES

01 karma is providence renamed	R1 causal-moral regularity is IMPERSONAL: nothing selects, forgives, rewards out of love, or answers
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02 devotional Mahayana is theism	R2 performing a function is not occupying the creator role
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03 Dharma is God renamed	R3 functional similarity does not establish ONTOLOGICAL IDENTITY
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THE COST TO CONCEDE: petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God, and Buddhism does without them. Its devotional structure is DIFFERENTLY SHAPED, not absent.

VERDICT: a strong ACTUAL counterexample - PROVIDED religion is defined multidimensionally rather than stipulated as God-relation, in which case it would be excluded before being examined.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/26: Jainism - motive, embodiment, and an achieved divinity

THE JAIN CASE AGAINST A CREATOR - two arguments, both with premises

1. THE MOTIVE ARGUMENT

a perfect being lacks any unfulfilled
desire; creation would answer a need;
a perfect being has no need
∴ no motive to create

2. THE EMBODIMENT ARGUMENT

action on matter requires a body or instrument
a body is itself made and limited
∴ an embodied creator is not the UNLIMITED
creator that was claimed

SAME ARGUMENT FAMILY: Kumarila's Slokavarttika against a BODILESS AGENT acting upon matter.

WHAT REPLACES THE CREATOR

eternal souls (jiva) + non-soul (ajiva)
KARMIC MATTER that binds and is shed
VOWS and asceticism
liberation as the soul's OWN achievement

WHAT IS VENERATED

TIRTHANKARA - the ford-maker who TEACHES the path
SIDDHA - the perfected soul, passionless (vitaraga):
grants nothing, hears nothing, governs nothing

THE DECISIVE LINE: an ACHIEVED divinity, never a GOVERNING one.

THEIST'S BEST SHOT HERE: "worship of a passionless being is really commemoration, so Jainism is a philosophy with ceremonies." REPLY: commemoration of a human exemplar does not carry vows, a ritual calendar, temple practice, ascetic discipline and a soteriological goal. A category that excludes this is tracking THEISM, not religion.

TRAP: never call the siddha a creator God under another name - that concedes the hidden-God objection in the one place where the Jain case is strongest.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/26: Mimamsa I - the three jobs an author would have done

IF SCRIPTURE HAD AN AUTHOR YOU WOULD NEED

- (a) a speaker whose reliability can be established
- (b) an external validator of the text's authority
- (c) a convention fixing what the words mean

MIMAMSA'S REMOVAL

APAURUSEYA: the Veda is AUTHORLESS, so there is no reliability question to answer at all
SVATAH-PRAMANYA: injunctions are INTRINSICALLY valid; validity is not conferred from outside
the WORD-REFERENT relation is ETERNAL
(sabdartha-sambandha nityatva) - Nyaya DENIES this as merely conventional: note the dispute

JAIMINI, MIMAMSA-SUTRA 1.1.2: "codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah"

dharmā = that which is CHARACTERISED BY (Vedic) INJUNCTION and is beneficial

==> dharmā is known ONLY from injunction - not from perception, not from inference, and not from any deity's command. Quote the sutra FOR THIS CONSEQUENCE or not at all.

AND THE DEITIES IN THE MANTRAS? they are ELEMENTS WITHIN THE RITUAL STRUCTURE - the dative to which the oblation is offered - NOT agents who hear, choose and grant.

EFFECT ON THEISTIC PROOFS: Udayana's arguments from the Veda's status (vakyat / pratyayatah / sruteh) lose their PREMISE rather than their conclusion.

TRAP: one careless sentence calling the Veda "revelation" reinstates the divine speaker the school has just removed, and surrenders the whole counterexample.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/26: Mimamsa II - the five-step argument for apurva

- 1 a Vedic injunction PROMISES a result (heaven from the jyotistoma)
- 2 the result does NOT follow immediately upon the act
- 3 the act is momentary and PERISHES
- 4 a PERISHED CAUSE cannot produce a LATER EFFECT
- 5 ∴ the act must generate an UNSEEN POTENCY that persists until the result matures
= APURVA, "the not-before" - something new that did not previously exist

EPISTEMIC STATUS: a POSTULATE (arthapatti), NEVER a perceived entity. Mimamsa's own epistemology licenses postulation to explain an otherwise inexplicable fact - so this is a SANCTIONED move, neither an observation nor an arbitrary invention.

WHY THIS REMOVES GOD, PART TWO: no DISPENSER of karmic fruit is needed, since apurva does that work - so the Nyaya argument that a superintendent of karma (karmadhyaksa) is required is ANSWERED DIRECTLY rather than ignored.

STATE ALL FIVE STEPS OR NONE: a bare assertion that ritual generates apurva, without the perished-cause problem, reads as vocabulary rather than as argument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/26: Mimamsa III - Kumarila against Prabhakara, and three objections

KUMARILA BHATTA

apurva = a POWER (sakti) residing in
the act or the agent, linking act
to fruit

=> a CONSEQUENTIAL MECHANISM OF DESERT

THE DIFFERENCE MATTERS: naming the two without the desert-versus-duty payoff is name-dropping.

THREE OBJECTIONS, THREE REPLIES

O1 (Nyaya) an unconscious potency cannot SELECT the appropriate fruit for the appropriate agent
at the appropriate time; only an intelligent superintendent can.

R1 the relation is LAW-LIKE, not deliberative; the objection assumes that only agents produce
determinate outcomes, which BEGS THE QUESTION against natural law.

O2 how can a beginningless, authorless text have determinate meaning?

R2 meaning is carried by the ETERNAL relation of word and referent (Nyaya denies it: dispute).

O3 is this religion, or bureaucracy?

R3 it has a sacred order, a soteriological promise, a disciplined practice and a community -
exactly what a functional definition requires.

HONEST LIMIT (?): later Mimamsa authors drift toward theism. The atheistic reading defended here
is of the CLASSICAL system - say so, and the answer is protected from an easy correction.

VERDICT FORMULA: "Mimamsa keeps scripture, ritual, duty, merit and a soteriological goal, and
relocates AUTHORITY and EFFICACY in apauruseya Veda and apurva. What it thereby shows is that
the religious functions God performs are SEPARABLE."

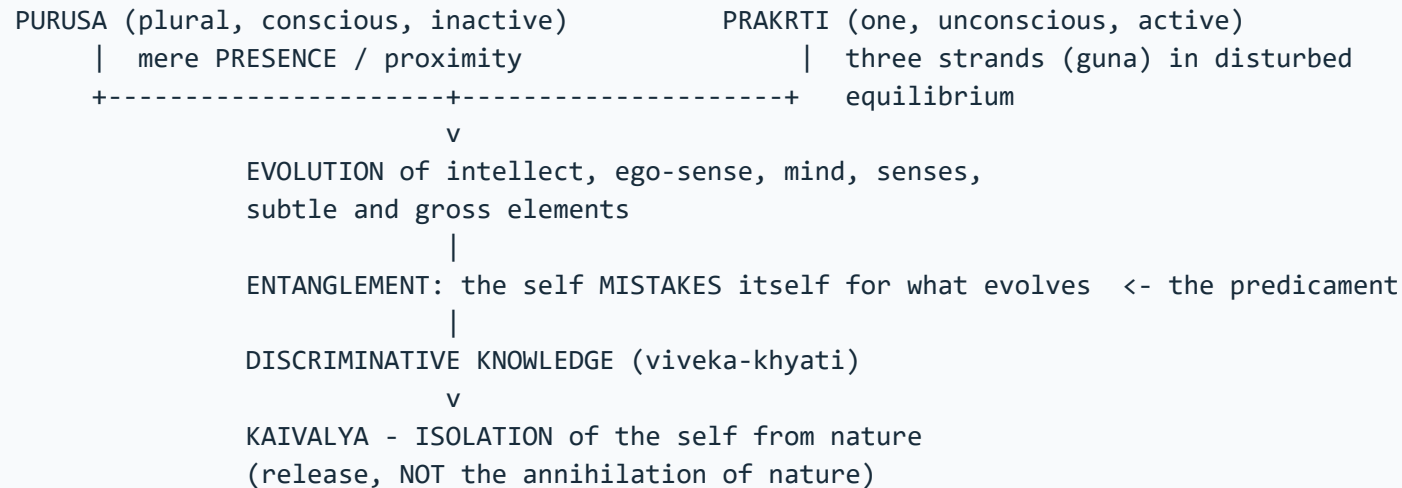
PRABHAKARA MISRA

recentres on NIYOGA / KARYA - the sheer

"OUGHT-TO-BE-DONE" disclosed by the injunction,
which motivates without needing a promised fruit

=> a DEONTOLOGY OF THE INJUNCTION

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/26: Samkhya and Yoga - a cosmos without a maker



WHERE IS THE CREATOR? nowhere; nothing in the sequence requires one.

YOGA'S ISVARA: a SPECIAL SELF, untouched by affliction and action - NOT straightforwardly a creator in the classical Samkhya sense. DO NOT read Yoga's Isvara back into Samkhya; that single editorial accident converts a non-theistic system into a theistic one.

PRESUPPOSITION: impersonal law or dual principles can explain order AND liberation.

NYAYA PRESSURE: an unconscious principle cannot organise ENDS.

REPLY: observed regularity need not be modelled on ARTEFACT PRODUCTION. Standard illustration - milk seeming to nourish the calf: non-conscious purposiveness with nothing deliberating. This reply is the GENERAL form of the anti-design answer in this clause; it also serves Buddhism and Mimamsa.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/26: Carvaka I - perception alone, and the four-element ontology

WHY ONLY PERCEPTION (pratyaksa)?

- 1 a means of knowledge (pramana) must yield CERTAINTY about its object
- 2 perception is self-evident and immediately certain
- 3 every other candidate - inference, comparison, testimony, postulation - is either reducible to perception or DEPENDS ON A GENERAL RULE that perception cannot certify
- 4 $\therefore$ perception alone is a pramana, and knowledge does not extend beyond the perceptible

THE ONTOLOGY THAT FOLLOWS

reality = the FOUR GROSS ELEMENTS (bhutacatustaya): earth, water, fire, air
ETHER IS REJECTED because it is IMPERCEPTIBLE - not an omission but a consequence
the human ends (purusarthas) reduce to KAMA and ARTHA, because the other two require a supersensible order to be intelligible

THE CERTAINTY CONDITION IS THE HINGE - and it is where the school is most vulnerable:

PARITY OBJECTION: perception itself faces illusion, dream and defective organs, and is corrected only by further cognition. So either the certainty condition is weakened - and inference re-enters - or perception fails its own test.

NOTE THE SHAPE OF THE CONCLUSION: it is ALREADY DOMAIN-RESTRICTED in its own statement - inference "works by luck or habit" in daily life and is worthless where no perceptual check exists. That restriction is what makes the moderate reading available in Panel 17.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/26: Carvaka II - the attack on inference, in full

INFERENCE (anumana) depends on VYAPTII - an INVARIABLE, UNCONDITIONAL concomitance between the mark (hetu, e.g. smoke) and the inferred (sadhya, e.g. fire).

CARVAKA'S QUESTION: by what means is VYAPTII ITSELF known?

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| (1) NOT BY PERCEPTION - perception grasps only PARTICULAR co-presences, here and now. |
| Vyapti is a UNIVERSAL covering all cases, including unobserved past, future and remote |
| ones, and no perception reaches those. |
| (2) NOT BY INFERENCE - establishing this vyapti by another inference requires that |
| inference's own vyapti: INFINITE REGRESS or CIRCULARITY. |
| (3) NOT BY TESTIMONY - testimony's authority would itself have to be established, and for |
| the Carvaka it is not a pramana at all. |
| (4) THE UPADHI PROBLEM - even repeated observation cannot rule out an unnoticed CONDITIONING |
| FACTOR (upadhi) that makes the concomitance hold only contingently. Standard example: |
| fire is accompanied by smoke ONLY WHEN THE FUEL IS WET. Unless every possible upadhi is |
| excluded - and that exclusion is itself unverifiable - the concomitance remains merely |
| PROBABLE: deviation (vyabhicara) stays possible. |
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CONCLUSION: inference cannot deliver CERTAINTY. Where it works in daily life it works by luck or habit; and precisely in the supersensible domain - God, soul, karma, afterlife - no perceptual check is EVER available, so there inference is worthless.

TRAP: "Carvaka rejects inference" states a CONCLUSION and omits the ARGUMENT the 2025 directive asked for. Give all four moves, including the upadhi residue.

- (a) GOD never perceived => the inference from world-as-effect to an intelligent maker is DOUBLY worthless: unperceived object, uncertifiable concomitance
- (b) THE SOUL not a separate substance: consciousness is an EMERGENT property of the body (dehatmavada). Standard analogy: the INTOXICATING POWER (madasakti) arising when fermenting ingredients (kinva etc.) are combined, though present in none singly. => no survival, no transmigration, NO LIBERATION - the whole soteriology goes
- (c) KARMA and unseen merit (adrsta) - imperceptible postulates invented to prop up ritual
- (d) THE VEDA authority denied. The verses transmitted in Madhava's Sarvadarsanasamgraha and attributed there to BRHASPATI mock the fire-sacrifice, the three Vedas and ascetic practice as the livelihood of the witless.  
(?) ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE: these survive ONLY as quotations in OPPONENTS' works. Treat them as REPORTED Carvaka positions, never as verified primary text; and never present the hedonist couplet ("yavaj jivet sukham jivet...") as more than a doxographic quotation, or build an answer on it.
- (e) ORDER SVABHAVA-VADA: things behave according to their OWN NATURE. The sharpness of a thorn and the colour of a peacock require no maker.

NOTE THE PARALLEL: (e) is the Carvaka counterpart of the Samkhya anti-design reply in Panel 13 - but stronger, because it declines the supersensible altogether rather than relocating it.



- 1 SELF-REFUTATION "no inference is valid" is itself a UNIVERSAL claim about all inferences, which cannot be perceived and must therefore be INFERRED. The thesis defeats itself.  
==> REJOINER A: advance the denial DIALECTICALLY, as a PRASANGA (reductio) internal to the opponent's own commitments, asserting no positive universal of one's own.
- 2 PRAGMATIC no one, including the Carvaka, can eat, speak, teach or argue without relying on inference; performative consistency demands its acceptance.
- 3 NYAYA'S POSITIVE DEFENCE OF VYAPTI
  - (i) repeated uncontradicted co-observation (bhuyodarsana)
  - (ii) NON-OBSERVATION OF ANY COUNTER-INSTANCE (vyabhicara-adarsana)
  - (iii) TARKA - hypothetical reasoning showing that denying the concomitance leads to absurdity plus the technical device samanya-laksana-pratyasatti, explaining how a universal is cognitively available at all
- 4 PARITY perception itself errs - illusion, dream, defective organs - and is corrected only by further cognition; certainty is not perception's exclusive property either
- 5 (?) THE MODERATE STRAND - and the one that separates a top script  
a strand associated with the fragmentary PURANDARA is REPORTED as accepting inference for ORDINARY empirical matters (laukika) while rejecting it as a route to the SUPERSENSIBLE (alaukika / atindriya).  
==> REJOINER B: on this reading the school is NOT committed to self-refuting global scepticism. Its thesis becomes the far more defensible one that inference cannot be extended beyond the domain in which its concomitances can be PERCEPTUALLY CHECKED - a classical Indian anticipation of the empiricist critique of metaphysics.  
(?) the evidence is fragmentary and reported by opponents: flag it as a REPORTED strand.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/26: Carvaka V - the classification verdict and its payoff

IS CARVAKA A "RELIGION WITHOUT GOD"? ==> NO. And saying so precisely is the mark-earning move.

no soteriology | no sacred | no community of practice | no ultimate concern

ITS PLACE IN THE CLAUSE: the LIMITING CASE at the other end.

Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa show that religion can survive the LOSS OF GOD.

Carvaka shows what happens when the EPISTEMIC ROUTE TO ANY SUPERSENSIBLE OBJECT is closed:

you get not a godless religion but NO RELIGION AT ALL.

THE PAYOFF: the contrast establishes that what non-theistic religions retain is NOT merely a

substitute deity but an ACCEPTED SUPERSENSIBLE ORDER - dharma, karma, nirvana, apurva -

which Carvaka alone rejects.

VERDICT FORMULA (write it): "Carvaka's critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does.

If the STRONG thesis is held - perception alone - it is self-refuting and pragmatically

unliveable. If the MODERATE thesis is held - inference is admissible only where its

concomitance can in principle be perceptually checked - the critique is powerful, unrefuted,

and fatal to every anumana-based natural theology, including Udayana's."

WHY THE MISCLASSIFICATION IS SO COSTLY: candidates reach for Carvaka as the obvious "godless

Indian school", and thereby show they think ABSENCE OF GOD is the criterion. Placing it

correctly is the fastest available demonstration that you know what the criterion actually is.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/26: Western critiques of theistic religion - four critics, one limit

| CRITIC    | THE CLAIM                                                                                                                 | NAMED SOURCE                                                                           |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FEUERBACH | "theology is anthropology"; God is the PROJECTION of humanity's idealised essence                                         | The Essence of Christianity                                                            |
| MARX      | religion is "the OPIUM OF THE PEOPLE" - a consoling illusion masking economic exploitation; dissolves with a just society | Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right, 1843-44 |
| FREUD     | religion is an ILLUSION: wish-fulfilment and cosmic father-projection                                                     | Freud on religion as illusion                                                          |
| COMTE     | replace the OBJECT: a positive RELIGION OF HUMANITY - devotion to human values without a deity                            | Comte's Religion of Humanity                                                           |

THE SHARED STRUCTURE: identify a human need, fear or condition -> show the belief would be produced by it anyway -> conclude the belief is fully EXPLAINED without the object.

WHAT THIS ESTABLISHES: the belief is NOT SELF-AUTHENTICATING. "People believe, therefore there is something to believe in" is blocked.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT ESTABLISH: that the object does not exist. A TRUE belief can also have a psychological or economic cause. ==> THE GENETIC-FALLACY LINE: ORIGIN DOES NOT SETTLE TRUTH.

WHERE THEY LEAD IN THIS CLAUSE: toward SECULAR HUMANISM and Comte's religion of humanity - which is why the clause routes them onward to the Humanism / Secularism owner rather than developing them for their own sake.

THE ARGUMENT IN FOUR STEPS

- 1 modern truthfulness and science ERODE traditional belief
- 2 inherited values DEPENDED on that framework
- 3 their collapse creates NIHILISM
- 4 overcoming it requires REVALUATION OF ALL VALUES and self-creation (the Übermensch)

PRESUPPOSITION: values have GENEALOGIES tied to forms of life, and can be assessed as life-enhancing or life-denying.

CANONICAL EXAMPLE: RESSENTIMENT reverses aristocratic value terms and converts weakness into moral superiority.

THE DISTINCTION THAT MUST BE MADE: "God is dead" is a CULTURAL DIAGNOSIS, not a syllogism proving that God does not exist, and not an empirical report about an event.

OBJECTION -> REPLY: revaluation risks elitism and arbitrary power ==> the Nietzschean reply appeals to creative self-overcoming, though a universal normative standard remains difficult. The self-reference is acknowledged rather than escaped.

===== THE OWNERSHIP GATE =====

The printed 2025 stem - "Present an account of Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality" - couples religion WITH morality and is owned by the RELIGION AND MORALITY clause. The full genealogical dossier (slave revolt, ascetic ideal, Beyond Good and Evil, the criticisms and the Indian comparison) lives there.

THIS clause retains Nietzsche as (a) a critique of THEISTIC religion and (b) the BRIDGE to post-theistic value.

THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS THE MARK: a horizon LOST is not a horizon NEVER HAD. Buddhism and Jainism never possessed what Nietzsche is mourning, so post-theism and non-theism must be argued in SEPARATE paragraphs.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/26: Agnosticism - the definition, the two strengths, the relation

### PART ONE - WHAT AGNOSTICISM IS

the existence of God is UNKNOWN or UNKNOWABLE ==> suspend judgement.

DISTINCT FROM ATHEISM, which DENIES; and from INDIFFERENCE, which does not raise the question.

WEAK AGNOSTICISM

STRONG AGNOSTICISM

"not known"

"unknowable"

contingent: evidence may underdetermine principled: the question exceeds the reach of

the question => open to future evidence human knowledge => closed in principle, and

therefore itself a substantial epistemological

thesis needing its own defence

COINAGE: "agnostic" was coined by T. H. HUXLEY in 1869.

ADJACENT POSITIONS: Kant's practical faith; Spencer's "Unknowable".

### PART TWO - HOW AGNOSTICS RELATE RELIGION AND GOD (the SECOND printed deliverable)

the two are SEPARABLE. An agnostic may affirm religion's ETHICAL dimension (conduct, compassion),

its EXPERIENTIAL dimension (contemplation, awe), and its COMMUNAL and RITUAL dimensions, while

WITHHOLDING assent on the EXISTENCE of God ==> a NON-THEISTIC or MINIMAL religiosity.

PRESUPPOSITION, stated honestly: religious commitment can be GRADED and need not include metaphysical certainty.

CANONICAL CASE: a person may participate in Buddhist ethical and meditative practice while withholding creator claims.

OBJECTION -> REPLY: this reduces religion to ethics or aesthetics ==> community, ritual, transformation and orientation to ultimacy EXCEED ordinary morality.

TRAP: answering only Part One forfeits half the marks on the 2023 stem.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/26: Religious naturalism - the modern question, and its bench

WHY THE MODULE EXISTS: Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa show religion without God in CLASSICAL forms.

The modern debate asks a sharper question: can someone who accepts a NATURALISTIC ONTOLOGY nonetheless be religious?

THESIS: ultimacy, reverence and the religious response are located WITHIN NATURE; there is no supernatural person, but nature sustains genuine attitudes of awe, gratitude, humility, commitment.

THINKER

NAMED WORK

THESIS IN ONE LINE

JOHN DEWEY

A Common Faith, 1934

distinguishes "religion" (an institution with supernatural claims) from "THE RELIGIOUS" (a quality of experience that unifies the self toward inclusive ideal ends); proposes using "God" for the ACTIVE RELATION BETWEEN THE IDEAL AND THE ACTUAL "RELIGIOUS ATHEISM": reject a personal God while holding that human life has OBJECTIVE INTRINSIC meaning and the universe is SUBLIME; VALUE REALISM, not theism, is core the religious response to natural depth religious attitude within evolutionary naturalism

RONALD DWORKIN

Religion without God, 2013

URSULA GOODENOUGH

The Sacred Depths of Nature, 1998

JULIAN HUXLEY

evolutionary humanism

CROSBY and RUE

nature as the ground of ultimacy

SPINOZA

Deus sive Natura

immanent locus of ultimacy

the historical ancestor of the family

OBJECTION -> REPLY: this is ethics and aesthetics wearing religious vocabulary; nothing is worshipped, nothing saves ==> ultimacy, reverence, communal practice and self-transformation are all present, and demanding a supernatural PERSON simply RESTATES the theistic definition.

HONEST CONCESSION: strongest where real practices and communities accompany the philosophy; otherwise "religious" survives chiefly as an ADJECTIVE for a quality of experience.

BOUNDED CAUTION: civil religion and secular spirituality are BOUNDARY TESTS, not owners, and never substitutes for the Indian cases: without a transformative discipline the category is too broad.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 23/26: Fictionalism, its rivals, and the Indian graded-truth control

THREE MODERN POSITIONS - the dividing line is ASSERTION

| ERROR THEORY         | NON-COGNITIVISM                       | FICTIONALISM                                                     |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the claims are FALSE | the claims NEVER HAD truth-conditions | the claims DO have truth-conditions, and are simply NOT ASSERTED |
| ==> STOP             | ==> never asserted                    | ==> ACCEPTED WITHIN the practice                                 |

NAMED POSITIONS

Don Cupitt, Taking Leave of God (1980) - NON-REALISM; God as the personification of the religious ideal; "Sea of Faith" theology

Robin Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism (1996) - explicit religious FICTIONALISM

Andrew Eshleman on the fictionalist's participation

Howard Wettstein on the significance of religious experience without metaphysical commitment

THREE OBJECTIONS -> THREE REPLIES

- (i) INSINCERITY / SELF-DECEPTION: worship presupposes belief; make-believe worship is dishonest or hollow. R: immersion in a fiction is a familiar, NON-DECEPTIVE human capacity - literature, ritual drama.
- (ii) MOTIVATIONAL: the practice's power derives from believing it true. R: fictionalists appeal to the sustained efficacy of narrative and ritual - an EMPIRICAL claim that remains CONTESTED.
- (iii) INTERNAL: believers themselves reject the description, so the account is REVISIONARY of the very thing it purports to save.

===== THE INDIAN COMPARISON - DO NOT OMIT =====

ADVAITA already contains a TWO-LEVEL apparatus doing structurally similar work WITHOUT fictionalism: worship of the qualified absolute (saguna) is GENUINELY EFFICACIOUS at the everyday level (vyavaharika) and is SUBLATED, not exposed as fiction, at the ultimate level (paramarthika).  
==> SUBLATION IS NOT FALSIFICATION.

BUDDHISM's TWO TRUTHS (samvrti / paramartha) permit full participation in conventional religious practice while denying ultimate substantial reference.

THE COMPARATIVE POINT THAT EARNS MARKS: Indian systems offer GRADED TRUTH where Western fictionalism offers PRETENCE - the Indian device preserves the practitioner's SINCERITY.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 24/26: The theist's denial, the rebuttal ledger, and the six-route bench

| THE THEIST'S DENIAL                                                                                           | THE REBUTTAL                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 DEFINITIONAL: religion IS relation to a personal transcendent => "religion without God" is a CATEGORY ERROR | Smart's dimensions; definition by STIPULATION is question-begging                                     |
| 2 DEVOTIONAL: worship requires a recipient; Jain vitaraga worship is "really commemoration"                   | Jain siddha = an ACHIEVED, not a GOVERNING, divinity; vows, ritual, asceticism, soteriology           |
| 3 MORAL: obligation requires a COMMANDER (divine command)                                                     | compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight, human flourishing                                       |
| 4 COSMIC ORDER: purposive order and karmic allotment require intelligence (Nyaya's Isvara as karmadhyaksa)    | MIMAMSA: apauruseya Veda + apurva secure authority, efficacy AND desert; LAW-LIKE is not DELIBERATIVE |
| 5 SOTERIOLOGICAL: grace and salvation require an AGENT who can give                                           | Buddhism's complete diagnosis-and-path structure                                                      |

THE ASSESSMENT THAT EARNS THE MARK: the theist's strongest SURVIVING point is (2) WORSHIP/GRACE, not (1) the definition. Petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God, and non-theistic religions do without them AT A REAL COST IN DEVOTIONAL STRUCTURE.

| ROUTE                     | REMOVED                                    | REPLACED BY                                             | RELIGION?        | PYQ        |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------|------------|
| Buddhism                  | creator + permanent self                   | dependent origination, Dharma, Sangha, nirvana          | YES              | 2024 Q7(a) |
| Jainism                   | creator only                               | karmic matter, vows, siddha                             | YES              | 2018       |
| Mimamsa                   | author of Veda AND dispenser of fruit      | apauruseya authority + apurva                           | STRONG           | 2020       |
| Samkhya/Yoga              | creator (Yoga keeps a non-creating Isvara) | prakrti's evolution; viveka-khyati; kaivalya            | YES              | 2021       |
| Naturalism / fictionalism | supernatural ontology, or assertion itself | nature as locus of ultimacy; practice without assertion | ONLY ON FUNCTION | 2018       |
| Carvaka                   | the WHOLE supersensible order              | nothing - svabhava, this-worldly ends                   | NO (LIMIT)       | 2025 Q5(a) |

CONCLUSION: religion without God is possible; religion without a SACRED ORDER is not.



## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 25/26: PYQ routes and the graded verdict ladder

| YEAR | PART  | MARKS | EXACT DEMAND                                                                                           | ROUTE                                        |
|------|-------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q5(c) | 10    | Can you justify religion without God? Support...                                                       | definition + Buddhism/<br>Jainism + boundary |
| 2019 | Q6(c) | 15    | How would a religious person deny the possibility...                                                   | theist's 5 arguments<br>FIRST, then rebut    |
| 2020 | Q6(c) | 15    | Critically examine the concept of God as<br>prerequisite for a religion.                               | necessity test +<br>counterexamples          |
| 2021 | Q5(d) | 10    | Is religious life possible without the belief in<br>God? Discuss.                                      | one tradition as LIVED<br>practice, in depth |
| 2023 | Q5(e) | 10    | What is Agnosticism? How do agnostics conceptualize<br>the relation between religion and God? Discuss. | define + weak/strong +<br>the relation       |
| 2024 | Q7(a) | 20    | State and evaluate Buddhism as a religion without<br>God.                                              | statement complete,<br>THEN evaluation       |
| 2025 | Q5(a) | 10    | Discuss Carvaka's critique of the belief in the<br>existence of suprasensible entities.                | the EPISTEMOLOGY -<br>vyapti, not slogans    |

(2022 is the only year in 2018-2025 with no primary-owned part in this clause.)

### GRADED VERDICT LADDER

|        |         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                    |
|--------|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WEAK   | ~40%    | "Buddhism has no God but is a religion"                                                                                                                                                                                                   | no definition; "atheistic" loose                                   |
| AVG    | ~50%    | functional definition; Buddhism + Jainism                                                                                                                                                                                                 | theist's case not constructed;<br>Mimamsa missing                  |
| GOOD   | ~60%    | definition defended; one case in depth                                                                                                                                                                                                    | over-broad functionalism unpoliced;<br>devotional Mahayana ignored |
| STRONG | ~65-70% | substantive/functional dispute explicit;<br>two Indian cases; worship/grace met                                                                                                                                                           | naturalism/fictionalism absent;<br>Carvaka misclassified           |
| TOP    | ~70%+   | all the above + a DISCRIMINATING distinction (non-theistic != atheistic; apauruseya<br>!= revelation; sublation != fictionalism; Carvaka as limiting case) + the concession<br>that petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God |                                                                    |

ANSWER ARCHITECTURES

- 10 define -> doctrine in four steps -> distinguish the nearest confusion -> one objection -> verdict on whether God is necessary
- 15 substantive vs functional frame -> one Indian case in depth -> canonical example -> theistic objection and reply -> comparison with another school
- 20 define criteria -> full Buddhist/Jain/Mimamsa case -> creator critique -> devotional complication -> Western post-theistic comparison -> graded conclusion

QUOTATION DISCIPLINE: "God is dead" = The Gay Science 125 (also 108, 343), cultural diagnosis | "opium of the people" = Marx 1843-44, quote the fuller sentence | "theology is anthropology" = Feuerbach | "agnostic" coined by Huxley 1869 | Brahmajala DN 1, Agganna DN 27 | Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2 verified | Slokavarttika against a creator | A Common Faith 1934 | Religion without God 2013 | Taking Leave of God 1980 | Arguing for Atheism 1996 | The Sacred Depths of Nature 1998 | (?) Brhaspati verses, the hedonist couplet and Purandara: DOXOGRAPHIC / REPORTED ONLY.